



LUXURY FLIGHT

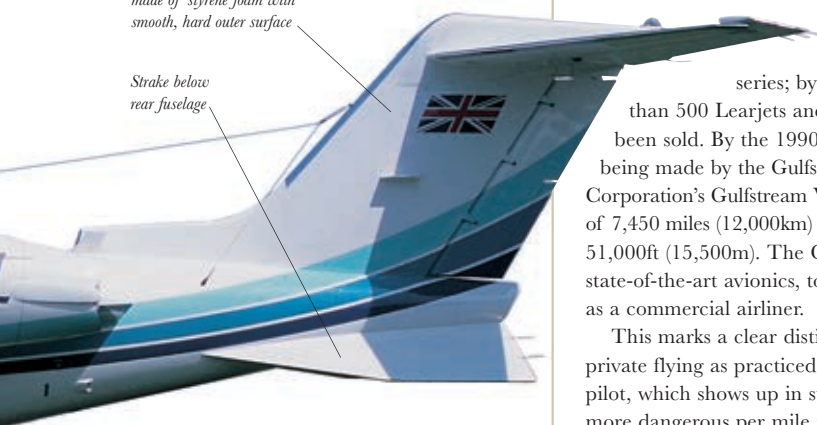
The Learjet 45 provides truly luxurious flight conditions for its nine passengers. Features include a spacious, flat-floor cabin; comfortable, fully reclining chairs; folding tables; and swiveling television monitors.

Specifications (Learjet 45)

ENGINE	2 x Allied Signal TFE731-20 turbofan
WINGSPAN	47ft 10in (14.6m)
LENGTH	52ft 8in (17.6m)
WEIGHT	13,550lb (6,146kg)
CRUISING SPEED	538mph (867kph)
CREW	2
PASSENGERS	9

Tail, wings, and fuselage made of styrene foam with smooth, hard outer surface

Strake below rear fuselage



TOP EXECUTIVE

The uncluttered, streamlined design of the Learjet 45 was realized with optimum aerodynamic efficiency in mind. One example of this is the 13-degree sweep of the wings.

The secret of the success of light aircraft has been their adaptability. Their functions have ranged from pilot training to aerial battlefield observation, from crop dusting to salting icy roads, from light commercial transportation to leisure flying.

Flying in the wild

In some of the world's wildest places, such as Alaska, the Amazon basin, or New Guinea, they have provided the main link between population centers and the only access to trackless wilderness. Although rarely recorded, the experiences of the pilots who fly Cessnas into the jungle airstrips of New Guinea's Bismarck Mountains, for example, have almost certainly been as demanding and hazardous as anything else in the entire history of flight.

There was a constant tendency for light aircraft to become more complex and more powerful, a response to the ready supply of private customers willing to pay the price for the latest in aviation technology. It was inevitable that this would eventually stretch to the private jet. Aimed largely at corporations, although also bought for personal use by the seriously rich, business jets have proliferated since the 1960s, freeing their owners from the straitjacket of airline timetables and from reliance on large commercial airports.

Status symbol

The trigger that set off the explosion of the executive-jet market was the Learjet, which became the ultimate 1960s status symbol, surpassing a luxury yacht or Manhattan penthouse for both glamour and desirability. The Learjet's

main rival in the early years was the Dassault Falcon

series; by the mid-1970s more than 500 Learjets and 300 Falcons had been sold. By the 1990s, the running was being made by the Gulfstream Aerospace Corporation's Gulfstream V, which had a range of 7,450 miles (12,000km) and could fly at 51,000ft (15,500m). The Gulfstream has state-of-the-art avionics, to make it as safe as a commercial airliner.

This marks a clear distinction from private flying as practiced by the amateur pilot, which shows up in statistics as far more dangerous per mile than driving a car. The figures are underlined by the media

NINETIES PACESETTER

The Gulfstream Aerospace Corporation's Gulfstream series set new performance levels for executive jets, as well as raising safety standards to match the airlines.

WILLIAM LEAR

WILLIAM POWELL LEAR (1902–78), the creator of the Learjet, was born in Hannibal, Missouri. A high-school dropout from an unsettled family background, he turned out to have a genius for electronics. He invented the first practical car radio in 1932 and subsequently, turning to aviation, created a wide range of electronic cockpit instruments. In 1947 Lear produced the first autopilot for jet aircraft, winning the prestigious Collier Trophy and making his fortune. After a spell in Switzerland in the 1950s, he returned to the United States and founded the Learjet Corporation in 1962. The success of the Learjet won him immense public renown, but he was not good at business. The firm was taken over by Gates Rubber Company in 1967. Lear subsequently frittered away a great deal of time and money on designing supposedly ecologically friendly steam-powered cars, as well as on the unsuccessful Learfan jet.



KING LEAR

The Learjet made William Lear a celebrity in the 1960s, able to pull in investment for any innovative technological project, however impractical it might be.

impact of crashes involving high-profile individuals – for example, the death of John F. Kennedy Jr. piloting a Piper Saratoga in 1999.

Knowing the risks involved is unlikely to deter any aviation enthusiast, whether in an expensive light aircraft or a hang-glider. The adventurous have always found occasional adrenaline-pumping danger part of the appeal of flight. Aviation is destined to retain a twin nature, as a central part of the practical business of the world, but also as one of those frontiers where individuals will sometimes go to test and prove themselves.

